An AI picked a robot vacuum.

A reviewer did the work.

Here’s who got paid:

The test.

Pete Pachal asked Meta's Muse assistant, which he named Jones, to pick a robot vacuum. The site it leaned on hardest: Vacuum Wars, a hands-on tester that takes no sponsorships.

Three big names never showed up.

Wirecutter, PCMag and Consumer Reports all have robot vacuum roundups. None appeared. Two of their owners are suing OpenAI. The third is members only.

Amazon was nowhere to be seen.

It blocked Muse from transacting shortly after launch. The sale went to Best Buy, Target and Dreame's own store.

“Also not getting paid: Vacuum Wars.”

Its business runs on affiliate links, and nearly all of them go to Amazon, which doesn’t exist inside Muse. The assistant used the testing and sent the sale elsewhere.

Every pick had a checkout page.

Jones recommended the Dreame L40 Ultra Gen 2, not the L60 Ultra PE its own summary singled out. Pachal can’t say why, but every product Muse recommended could be bought on the spot.

Blocking the bots won't save reviewers.

A thin repackaging of Vacuum Wars data got cited anyway. The testing gets in either way. The paycheck doesn't. And Amazon has cut some publishers' commissions by as much as 50 percent.

Two imperfect options for review publishers:

- Cut affiliate deals with the stores assistants can reach.
- Sell your test data to the AI companies.

Pete Pachal's bottom line: the irony of the AI era is that the people whose job is doing the unbiased, thorough research are the ones most shut out.

Full column at mediacopilot.ai. Link in bio.

Would you cut a deal with the store, or sell your test data to the AI company?